Pakistan will have to be dealt by India, added Subrahmanyam.[106] As India and Iran grew close, Benazir Bhutto's visit to Iran in November 1995 did little to change the negative Pakistan-Iran dynamic. The rise of the Sunni Taliban in Afghanistan and Shiite militancy within Pakistan restricted normalisation of relations between Islamabad and Tehran.[107] India's unconditional backing to Iran during the mid and late 1990s was visible in India's refusal to accept the Bill Clinton administration's efforts to link Iran with terrorism.[108]

Lalit Mansingh, former foreign secretary, states India's strategic dependence on Iran in Afghanistan during the 1990s and early 2001 as such:

> We [India] discovered that we could play a security role during the Taliban period when the Northern Alliance was formed. And since Russia and Iran were on the same page we were very comfortable in giving military assistance. But then we didn't have to worry about the routes because we had the active support of the Iranians. And therefore getting military supplies across to the Northern Alliance was not a big problem. With the help of the Russians and the Iranians we could do that. But the fact is that it also acknowledges that India can't work alone. India by itself cannot play a major role in the security situation of Afghanistan.[109]

To consolidate bilateral relations and signal strategic convergence between India and Iran, PM Vajpayee visited Tehran on 10 April 2001. A 'pathbreaking document', as external affairs and defence minister Jaswant Singh called it, the Teheran declaration emerged from the visit.[110] Emphasising the need for 'a broadbased government in Afghanistan, which reflects the aspirations of all Afghan people', the declaration firmly condemned the Sunni Taliban's extremism.[111] Despite the conciliator's endurance in 1992, changing regional alignments and particularly the Persian connection, proved fertile ground for the partisans' growth by 1996, and dominance afterwards.

## *Russia's bear hug*

Providing muscular agency to India and Iran's strategic convergence on Afghanistan was Moscow's threat to use force against the Taliban. Blaming Washington for helping the militia, Vladimir Lukin, international advisor to Russian President Boris Yelstin, said in October 1996 that brazen US interference in Afghan affairs to counter Iran was 'primitive and short-sighted'.[112] Having lost the First Chechen War in August 1996, and gone through the Nagorno-